



Ash berries

contact with water, produce the extremely poisonous prussic acid.

History & Folklore In the Scottish Highlands, this tree was believed to be a reliable antidote to witchcraft. Highlanders planted it near their houses,

and cowherds believed that by using an ash switch to drive their cattle they could protect them from evil influences. The fruit has long been used to make preserves and alcoholic drinks.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The astringent mountain ash is most often taken as a jam or an infusion to treat diarrhea and hemorrhoids. In addition, infusions may be used as a gargle for sore throats and as a wash to treat hemorrhoids and excessive vaginal discharge.

Caution Remove the toxic seeds prior to using the fruit as a medicine or a food.

Spigelia marilandica (Loganiaceae) Pinkroot

Description Perennial plant with oval to lance-shaped leaves, spikes of brilliant red-pink flowers, and a double seed capsule.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the southern regions of the U.S., pinkroot flourishes in dry rich soil in clearings and along woodland borders. The root is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Pinkroot contains alkaloids (mainly spigeleine), a volatile oil, tannin, and resin. Spigeleine is emetic and irritant to the stomach.

History & Folklore Pinkroot was used extensively by Native Americans as a worm-expelling herb. It was gathered for trade with white settlers by the Creek and Cherokee peoples. From the late 18th century onward, pinkroot became one of the chief deworming herbs used in North America and Europe.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Pinkroot is used today solely to expel intestinal worms—particularly tapeworms and roundworms. It is prescribed with other herbs such as senna (*Cassia senna*, p. 75) and fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*, p. 212) to ensure the elimination of both the worms and the root itself, which is potentially toxic if it is absorbed through the gut.

Related Species Several *Spigelia* species act as worm-expelling herbs, for example *S. flemmingiana*, native to Brazil, and *S. anthelmia*, native to the Caribbean, Venezuela, and Colombia. *S. anthelmia* also contains isoquinoline alkaloids and is used in the treatment of heart disease.

Caution Only use pinkroot with the supervision of a professional practitioner.

Stachys officinalis syn. *S. betonica* (Lamiaceae)

Betony

Description Mat-forming perennial growing to a height of 2 ft (60 cm). Has toothed elliptical leaves and spikes of pink or white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Betony grows throughout most of Europe, and occurs in Asia as far east as the Caucasus, where it is found in meadows, heathland, and hilly areas. The aerial parts are collected when the plant is in flower during early summer.



Betony is an age-old headache remedy. Its name may derive from the Celtic for "good head."

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Betony contains alkaloids (including stachydrine and betonicine), as well as phenolic compounds, betaine, choline, and tannins.

History & Folklore Betony has been regarded as a panacea since classical times, even attributed with the ability to ward off evil spirits. Antonius Musa, physician to Emperor Augustus (63 BCE–14 CE), claimed that betony would cure 47 different illnesses. The herb has always been particularly valued as a remedy for headaches.

Medicinal Actions & Uses No longer regarded as a panacea, betony nevertheless has real value as a remedy for headaches and facial pain. The plant is also mildly sedative, relieving nervous stress and tension. In British herbal medicine, betony is thought to improve nervous function and to counter overactivity. It is taken to treat "frayed nerves," premenstrual complaints, poor memory, and tension. The plant has astringent properties, and in combination with other herbs, such as comfrey (*Symphytum officinale*, p. 138) and linden flowers (*Tilia* species, p. 277), it is effective against sinus headaches and congestion. Betony may be taken

alone or with yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*, p. 56) to help staunch nosebleeds. Betony is also mildly bitter. It stimulates the digestive system and the liver, and has an overall tonic effect on the body.

Caution Do not take betony if you are pregnant.

Stellaria media (Caryophyllaceae) Chickweed

Description Sprawling perennial growing to about 6 in (15 cm). Has hairy stems, oval leaves, and starlike white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and Asia, chickweed is now found in most regions of the world. It grows easily in wasteground, and is generally regarded as a troublesome weed. The plant is harvested in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Chickweed contains triterpenoid saponins, coumarins, flavonoids, carboxylic acids, and vitamin C. The saponins may account for the herb's ability to help reduce itchiness.

History & Folklore Dioscorides, a Greek physician writing in the 1st century CE, described chickweed's applications as follows: "it [chickweed] may usefully be applied with corn meal for inflammation of the eyes.

The juice may also



Chickweed can help to soothe eczema and other skin conditions.